



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

INVESTIGATORS look at Edison electrical lines and towers in Eaton Canyon on Feb. 11. The area is suspected as the starting point of the Eaton fire. The utility has said it did everything possible to prevent a wildfire.

Edison power lines overdue for ‘ignition risk’ repairs before fire

Company records detail work orders for towers near suspected origin of Eaton blaze.

By Connor Sheets

As investigators work to determine the cause of the Eaton fire, the focus has narrowed to several parallel power lines just outside Altadena owned by Southern California Edison.

Whether the company

was responsible for sparking the Jan. 7 blaze remains to be seen, but company records uncovered by The Times show for the first time that Edison knew some of its towers at and near the likely ignition point were fire hazards.

With evidence still being gathered — and dozens of lawsuits pending — the utility has maintained it did everything possible to prevent a wildfire.

But records the company filed with the state show towers on three lines now

under suspicion were considered a potential “ignition risk” and long overdue for critical upkeep.

Two of the lines were still active, delivering power to the area until after the fire broke out. A third line, which a company official said was built about a century ago, had been decommissioned in 1971, meaning it hadn’t carried electricity to customers for decades.

The mystery of how an unused line may have triggered an inferno has puzzled some following the case, but

experts said it’s possible given the circumstances.

Edison data reviewed by The Times show that as of Dec. 31, the utility had 94 open work orders along the three lines, portions of which run past the northern edge of Altadena and through Eaton Canyon. Company work order records since the start of the year were not available.

The orders were for a range of tasks, including clearing vegetation that could potentially ignite, fix- [See Lines, A6]

Musk team’s plans target environment in California

Nearly two dozen science-related offices in state face closure by the administration.

By Hayley Smith

President Trump’s so-called Department of Government Efficiency plans to terminate lease contracts at nearly two dozen California offices relating to science, agriculture and the environment, according to its federal database.

The planned closures include facilities occupied by the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, Environmental Protection Agency, National Park Service, Forest Service and Geological Survey. The terminations follow massive layoffs at NOAA and significant cuts to scientific research funding across federal agencies — including the potential elimination of the EPA’s key scientific research arm.

The Trump administration has said the lease terminations will provide considerable cost savings for the American people. Elon Musk’s DOGE website lists nearly 800 lease locations set for closure across the country totaling more than 10 mil-

lion square feet, which it says would result in about \$500 million in savings. The database does not provide specific addresses or information about what the buildings are used for.

As of Monday, 65 locations on the list were in California, and 22 of them — or about 35% — are home to agencies that help manage, protect and preserve the Golden State’s environment.

Among them is a NOAA office in Eureka that is home to an outpost of the agency’s National Marine Fisheries Service, which is geared toward the stewardship of oceans and marine life.

“NOAA provides critical information about extreme weather and coastal hazards, manages fisheries, conserves coastal and marine resources, and protects American fishermen and consumers,” wrote a group of Democratic lawmakers in a recent letter to Howard Lutnick, secretary of the Department of Commerce, which oversees NOAA.

“Closing field facilities will compromise NOAA’s ability to provide these services and damage the local communities and economies that rely on them,” wrote the group, which included California’s Reps. [See Environment, A9]

COLUMN ONE

In Altadena, a race to save vintage tiles ahead of bulldozers

By Laura J. Nelson

The team of masons, covered in dust and sweat, had been working in the ruins of the Altadena house for hours when a shout echoed across the wreckage.

Volunteer Devon Douglas emerged from a pit of rubble that had once been the living room, staggering under the weight of a concrete slab more than a foot wide.

“It’s a stair,” Douglas said, turning toward homeowner Valerie Elachi. “A whole stair, and all the tiles.”

It was a bittersweet moment for Elachi, 76, who had danced down that tiled staircase when she and her husband first saw the home during an open house in the early 1980s.

She watched from her patio wall as five volunteers chiseled the historic tiles from the stairs and from her massive living room fireplace. Having something to salvage was a gift, she thought, and a bitter reminder of all they had lost. [See Batchelder, A12]



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VINTAGE tiles that survived the Eaton fire are salvaged by a team of volunteers for safekeeping.



JEHAD ALSHRAFI Associated Press

ISRAEL ordered people to evacuate eastern Gaza, signaling ground operations could soon return. In Gaza City, the bodies of victims arrive Tuesday at a hospital.

Israeli forces resume strikes in Gaza, killing hundreds

Netanyahu orders bombardment after Hamas refuses to change cease-fire deal.

By Wafaa Shurafa, Josef Federman and Samy Magdy

DEIR AL BALAH, Gaza Strip — Israel launched airstrikes across the Gaza Strip early Tuesday, killing more than 400 Palestinians, local health officials said,

and shattering a cease-fire in place since January with its deadliest bombardment in a 17-month war with Hamas.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu ordered the strikes, which killed mostly women and children, after Hamas refused Israeli demands to change the cease-fire agreement. In a statement aired on national television, he said that the attack was “only the beginning” and that Israel would press ahead until it achieved all of its war aims — destroy-

ing Hamas and freeing all hostages held by the militant group.

All further cease-fire negotiations will take place “under fire,” he said. The White House said it had been consulted and voiced support for Israel’s actions.

The Israeli military ordered people to evacuate eastern Gaza and head toward the center of the territory, indicating that it could soon launch renewed ground operations. The new campaign comes as aid [See Gaza, A4]

Unpacking legal issues of hotels’ bans on children

By Christopher Reynolds

Can hotels legally ban children?

With spring breaks starting momentarily and summer vacations not far away, the question is puzzling a wide scope of California travelers — parents booking their next family vacation as well as adults looking for a child-free escape. And the answer is complicated.

The issue flared in February when the Alila Marea Beach Resort in Encinitas, part of the Hyatt hotel empire, announced it would exclude children as overnight guests, thus becoming the self-described “only adults-only oceanfront resort in Southern California.”

This move at a high-profile beachfront property sparked a debate about state law and hotels’ obligations and has turned eyes on other California hotels that exclude children. In the Palm Springs area, the Colony Palms, the Fleur Noire, the Ingleside Estate and La Maison Palm Springs are among the lodgings whose websites say they are adults-only. The Whisky Hotel, which opened March 12 in Hollywood, promotes itself similarly.

“We cater to adults only, because that’s kind of our vision,” said Whisky Hotel general manager Alan Esparza, noting the grown-up [See Hotels, A6]

Putin agrees to pause in war

Russia stops short of agreeing to a 30-day cease-fire sought by the U.S. **WORLD, A3**

Roberts criticizes Trump’s remark

Chief justice issues rare statement against president’s call to impeach a judge. **NATION, A5**

Gyrations in the stock market

Wall Street has plunged rapidly but was already looking overheated. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

Weather

Sunshine. L.A. Basin: 77/51. **B6**

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